

IN FROM THE MARGINS

From being shown as token buddies and gun-toting terrorists, Bollywood is now accepting modern Muslims as they are. Ordinary people with moral dilemmas and everyday concerns.

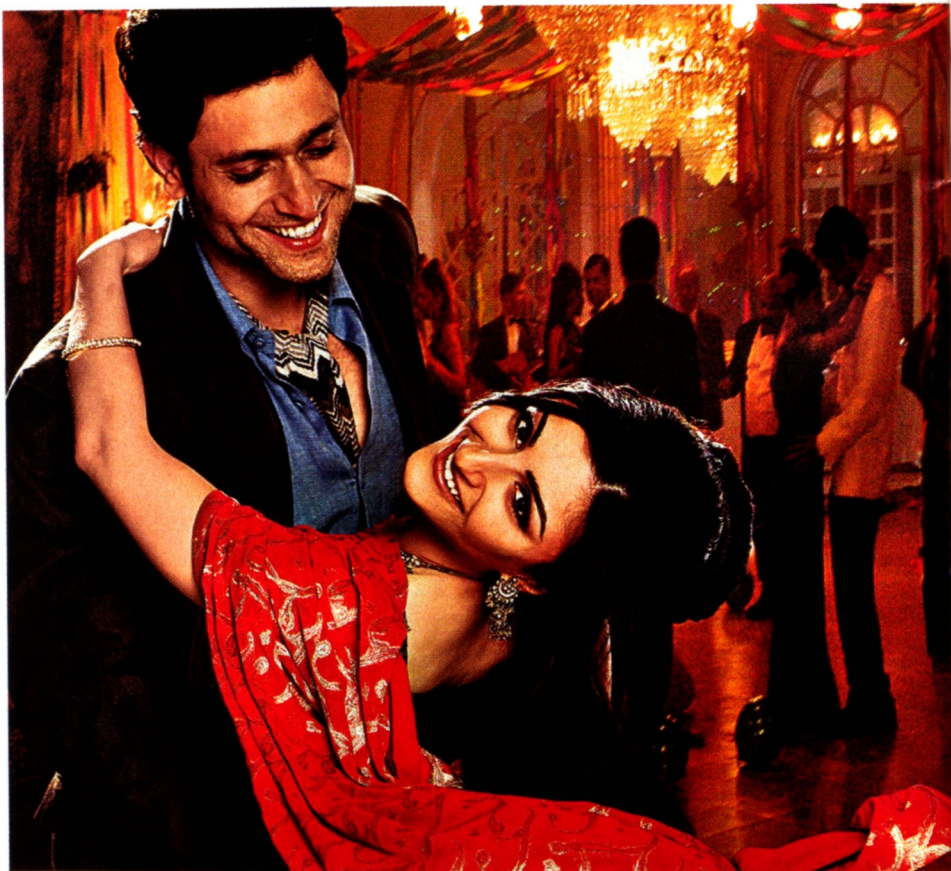
■ By Kaverie Bamzai

Ashfaq Khan is a young man who cuts his political teeth on the street theatre of Delhi, a man who moves to Mumbai to acquire fame as a star called Sameer Khan. Somewhere along the way he loses his humanity, until he remembers the philosophy behind *Halla Bol* (the late Safdar Hashmi's war cry). Instead of walking away from a murder trial, he becomes the chief witness.

In Rajkumar Santoshi's *Halla Bol*, Ashfaq Khan is played by a Hindu, Ajay Devgan. In Bollywood's usually cheesy Hindu-Muslim bhaihood, this would be a perfect advertisement for communal harmony. But the truth is that, for long, Bollywood Muslims have either been token friends or evil villains aligned to extra-territorial forces.

Surprisingly, the industry's top three actors, all Muslim, have done only four Muslim roles apiece. But a new cultural ethos, spurred by a savvy marketing sense, which understands the changing nature of society and the wider cross-religion appeal of Hindi movies, is transforming these caricatures. In *Chak De India*, for instance, Shah Rukh Khan plays a young modern Muslim, a disgraced hockey captain named Kabir Khan, loosely based on the life of Mir Ranjan Negi, India's goalkeeper in the 1982 Asian Games. The adverse reaction towards him in the movie does have something to do with his being a Muslim, and yet, notes Khan, he is as "Muslim as I am. He does not have a black spot on his forehead and does not speak in accented Urdu."

In *Awarapan*, which was co-produced by a Dubai-based Pakistani, Sohail Khan, and released in 20 theatres in Pakistan, there are two heroines, Alia, a Muslim girl from Jodhpur, and Reema, a sex slave from Pakistan. For director Mohit Suri, whose mother is a Muslim and father a Hindu Brahmin, a movie that moves



FAITH AND THE FILMS: Shinee Ahuja and Soha Ali Khan in *Khoya Khoya Chand* (above); Tulip Joshi in Pooja Bhatt's *Dhokha*

